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Flagstaff cancels controversial contract for Flock Safety cameras

The city of Flagstaff voted unanimously to end its contract with Flock Safety after months of privacy concerns. Mason Carroll reports.

By [Mason Carroll](#)

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FLAGSTAFF, AZ (AZFamily) — The city of Flagstaff just canceled its contract with the [surveillance camera company Flock Safety](#) this week after a unanimous city council vote.

Locals have been raising concerns over privacy issues for months, but the company said it's useful in finding missing people and criminals.

The cameras are pretty inconspicuous when you're just driving by, but over 30 Flock cameras can be found around Flagstaff.

Brendan Trachsel lives in Flagstaff. He said that after he learned Flock cameras were in town, he became concerned about his privacy.

"I look up on a lightpost, and I see a Flock camera installed, and my heart just sinks," Trachsel said. "It's the fact that they are keeping and maintaining a record of movements of all drivers, which, 99.8% of which will never be suspected of anything."

So he created "[Flock Out of Flag](#)." The purpose is to try and convince the city to end its contract with the company.

Flock is making state and national headlines. Their automated license plate reader technology is installed in several cities across the state, and it's been credited for solving crimes.

Earlier this year, their cameras in northern Arizona [helped law enforcement track down a missing toddler from California](#).

Just this week, the technology was credited with [helping find the Brown University shooting suspect](#).

At a recent City Council meeting in Flagstaff, police officers hailed the technology as an important tool.

"It aided in bringing justice to many victims in our community, and we had no incidents of misuse of the (Automated License Plate Recognition) system with our first year of the contract," said a police officer.

But Trachsel worries about who else has access to all that data. He said there has to be a middle ground and not a constant “Big Brother” gathering data on anyone and everyone.

“Flock goes way too far in one direction, and that personally, I believe a hot-list-only ALPR system would be a much better balance for the people of Arizona,” he said.

This week, dozens of people showed up at a City Council meeting, echoing those concerns.

“Approving this contract with Flock in trusts our private data to a company that will sacrifice honesty and integrity for profit,” said a woman who spoke at the meeting.

After months of back and forth, the council unanimously decided to end the contract.

Coconino County also has Flock cameras, with 18 of them currently installed. Trachsel said they will request that the county remove those cameras as well.

The city of Sedona also canceled its contract with Flock this fall. However, these cameras are still active across the state, including in Phoenix and Tucson. You can see if there is [a Flock camera near you by clicking/tapping here](#).

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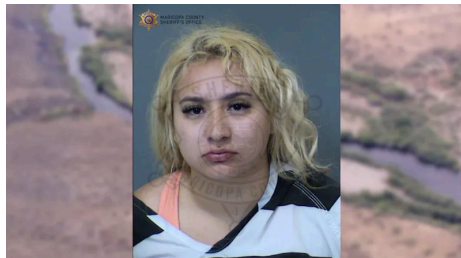
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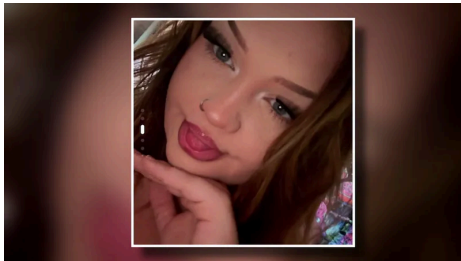
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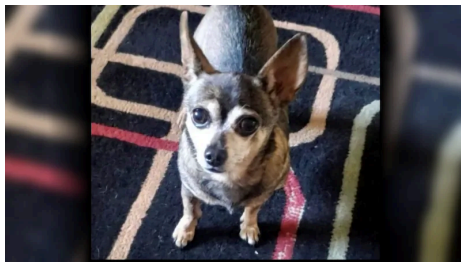
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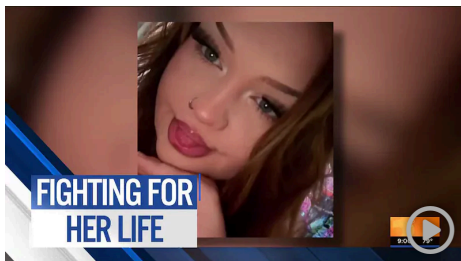
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